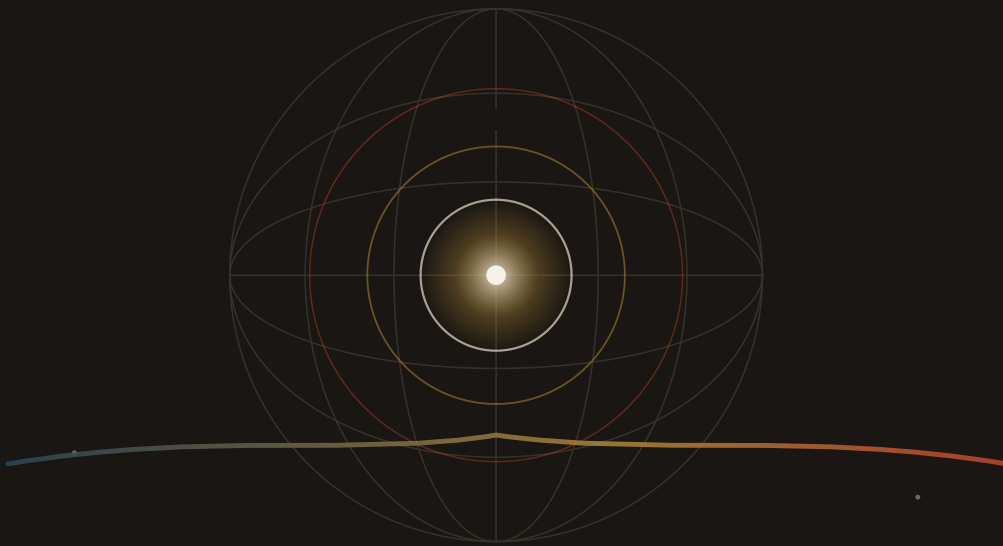


THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF
MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.



THE GOOD LIFE

**A rainbow, once, anywhere —
the Daytona nobody has ever
auctioned before**

CURIOSITIES

**The shark nobody had seen
alive — 125 million years,
unwitnessed**

THE GRAND TOUR

**Hokkaido: the lavender fields
hit their ten best days,
starting now**

IN THIS EDITION

I Refute It Thus

No. 39 · A Saturday book about which things are real either way, and which things are real because enough of us agreed.

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World eq.¹ 7,575 ▲ STI ~5,465 ▲ US 10Y 4.56% JGB 10Y 2.77–2.82%
Gold \$4,100–4,135 BTC ~\$64.3k ▲ Brent ~\$77 ▲ USD/SGD 1.2931

¹ VWRA proxied via S&P 500. Levels to Fri 10 Jul close where available; JGB 10Y held as an unresolved conflict, not a pick. Full read on the Macro Desk, p15. Not investment advice.

FROM THE DESK

"I refute it thus."

— Samuel Johnson, kicking a stone, as recorded in James Boswell's *Life of Johnson* (1791)

Johnson meant to refute Bishop Berkeley's claim that reality depends on being perceived — and famously missed the point while making a wonderful one anyway. This week's book kept handing us both kinds of stone: a shark real for 125 million unwitnessed years, and a chip stock whose price was never anything but what enough people agreed to believe. The discipline, all issue, was knowing which was which — and saying so honestly when we weren't sure.

28

PAGES · THE WEEKEND BOOK + TRAVEL

125M yrs

THE GOBLIN SHARK'S LINEAGE, UNWITNESSED UNTIL THIS MONTH

10–25 Jul

HOKKAIDO LAVENDER'S PEAK BLOOM WINDOW — THIS ISSUE LANDS INSIDE IT

13%

SK HYNIX'S FRIDAY CLOSE — BELIEF BECOMING PRICE, IN REAL TIME

This weekend's book leans lifestyle by design: the cover and all three teasers come from the Good Life, Curiosities and the Grand Tour rather than the wire, and the hard-news desks — The World, Singapore, Property, Technology — run leaner and more reflective than a weekday briefing. The Macro Desk carries a correction on itself this issue; The Family Desk asks a sharper question than the headline number invites; and the Travel Desk's four pages land, by calendar coincidence rather than design, inside the single best week of the year to read them.

THE WORLD · THE SAME ROOM, A NEW SIGN ON THE DOOR

"Over," and Still Going

Washington says the Hormuz ceasefire is finished. The negotiators are back at the same table in Doha today anyway — a reminder that a declaration and the thing it describes don't always move together.

On Friday, President Trump said the United States now considers the Hormuz ceasefire framework "over" — and then added, in the same breath, that Iran had asked to keep talking, and Washington had agreed.¹ It is a small inversion worth noticing: the label changed before the substance did. Qatari and Pakistani mediators spent Friday shuttling between separate rooms with the US and Iranian delegations in Doha, and negotiations covering sanctions relief, Iran's frozen funds and the nuclear file are reported set to resume today, Saturday, now that the week of mourning for Ayatollah Khamenei has ended.²

A correction is owed on last issue's read of Kharg Island. No. 38 described Iran's main export terminal as pointedly spared in the US strike wave; fresher reporting says military assets on or near Kharg were in fact hit — yet the supertanker *Berg 1* was still loading crude there as of Thursday.³ Read it as "touched, not knocked out" rather than either version standing alone. Tanker traffic through the strait, meanwhile, slowed further on Friday, and the IEA puts global oil supply still 9.4 million barrels a day below pre-war levels even after June's partial recovery.³

WHY DOHA, AND WHY TWO ROOMS

THE MEDIATORS

Qatar and Pakistan are running parallel, not joint, channels — separate rooms with each delegation rather than a single shuttle table. It's a slower format, but a more forgiving one: neither side has to be seen sitting across from the other while emotions from the funeral week are still raw.

The ceasefire is "over." The negotiators are back in the same room. Both sentences are true, and only one of them tells you what's actually happening.

The Gulf states, for their part, are done waiting for Washington and Tehran to sort it out between themselves. A fresh GCC statement this week set its own terms for what a lasting peace requires: not just a pause, but Iran renouncing "the full spectrum" of its threats — missiles, drones, proxy support — and guaranteeing free transit through Hormuz.⁴ It is sharper and more specific than the bloc's earlier, more general appeals for calm.

THE CHATTER

Sceptics note that the Doha channel never actually closed — talks have run more or less continuously since late June, funeral week aside. "Ceasefire over" may be less a change in the diplomacy than a change in how Washington wants the diplomacy to sound: pressure applied, not abandoned.

— NBC News, CNN live coverage (10 Jul)

WHAT'S ACTUALLY ON THE TABLE

Three baskets, per reporting: sanctions relief, the release of Iran's frozen overseas funds, and the nuclear file itself. Only the last of those is genuinely new territory — sanctions and frozen funds have been under discussion since the original 60-day framework.

Hormuz's importance is easy to state and easy to under-feel: roughly a fifth of the world's seaborne oil and a comparable share of its liquefied natural gas move through a channel barely three kilometres wide at its narrowest shipping lane. That geography is precisely why both a toll regime and a multinational escort mission remain live options on the table — whoever controls the practical logistics of the strait controls a lever neither capital wants to hand the other.

SOURCES 1. NBC News (10 Jul 2026); CNN live updates. 2. Times of Israel liveblog (10 Jul). 3. US News, Hormuz tanker traffic (9–10 Jul); IEA. 4. GCC joint statement, via Al Jazeera (Jul 2026).

TWO FRAMINGS OF ONE "OVER"

WASHINGTON**NBC / CNN FRAMING**

The ceasefire's end is recast as leverage, not failure: Iran is the party that came back asking to keep talking, which the administration reads as proof the pressure campaign worked. Denuclearization, Trump says, is "moving along well" — the label change is presented as strength, not a step backward.

THE GULF STATES**GCC STATEMENT / AL JAZEERA FRAMING**

Riyadh, Doha and Abu Dhabi are no longer content to be the geography two other capitals argue over. Their statement sets independent terms — missiles, drones, proxy militias, guaranteed Hormuz transit — for what a real peace has to include, regardless of what Washington and Tehran privately call the current state of play.

Between the two: a fifth of the world's seaborne oil once passed through Hormuz in peacetime, and traffic is still labouring to recover from a near-standstill earlier in the week. Whatever word gets attached to the ceasefire this weekend, the tankers are the honest gauge — and they slowed again on Friday, not the other way around.¹

ALSO ON THE WIRE**THE PITCH, TODAY**

The World Cup's quarterfinal weekend continues: Norway face England and Argentina face Switzerland later today, after Spain's dramatic 88th-minute win over Belgium set up a semi-final against France.²

THE LISTING, CLOSED OUT

SK hynix's Nasdaq debut — flagged as an open question last issue — resolved emphatically Friday: shares closed up 13%, and the \$26.5bn raise is now confirmed as the largest-ever US listing by a foreign company, ahead of Alibaba's 2014 record (see Technology, p7).³

MASHHAD, ONE LINE

Mojtaba Khamenei, named successor to his father in February, still has not appeared in public — unchanged since last issue, and increasingly a story in itself.

THE HONEST GAUGE

335 vessels transited Hormuz the week before last; this week's count is down again. Watch the shipping lanes, not the press conferences, for the real state of the truce.

THE BRACKET AHEAD

The World Cup final lands 19 July. Spain–France is now set for one semi-final; Saturday's two quarterfinals — Norway–England, Argentina–Switzerland — decide the other.

THE OIL GAP, IN ONE FIGURE

9.4 million barrels a day — global supply's shortfall against pre-war levels, even after June's partial recovery. That gap, not any single day's headline, is the number that ultimately sets the price at the pump.

THE SCEPTIC

A weekend caution: don't over-read a single word choice in either direction. "Over" hasn't stopped the talking, but "talking" hasn't yet reopened the strait to its pre-war traffic either. The honest state of play is a ceasefire that changed its name without yet changing its facts on the water. Readers who want the fuller argument for why this distinction matters — a label that changes before the substance does — will find it running through this whole issue, closing with the Long Read, p25.

READING THE TWO PANELS TOGETHER

Notice what the two framings actually share, underneath the disagreement: both Washington and the Gulf states are now speaking as though the original bilateral shape of this crisis — one superpower, one regional power — has already given way to something more crowded. Washington's version reframes Iran's continued presence at the table as evidence its own strategy worked; the Gulf statement simply stops asking permission to have its own terms at all. Whichever telling turns out to be closer to the eventual outcome, both capitals have quietly stopped treating this as a two-party negotiation, and that shift — not the word "over" — may be the more durable news of the week.

SINGAPORE • TONIGHT'S FIREWORKS

The Parade Comes Home to the Stadium

After a decade at the Padang, National Day's rehearsal season opens tonight back at the National Stadium — a genuine homecoming for a show that outgrew its old address, and tonight's fireworks are free to watch.

National Education Show 1 (NE1) — the first of this season's preview and rehearsal shows — runs tonight at the National Stadium, Kallang, with fireworks over the bay from around 7.30pm.¹ The address itself is the news: after ten years staged at the Padang, NDP is back at the Stadium, the venue it started outgrowing in the first place. The same Saturday-night fireworks slot repeats on 18 and 25 July and 1 August, building to the parade proper on 9 August — four free chances to catch the show before the ballot-only main event, and an easy, no-planning family outing this weekend.

Away from the parade ground, a quieter but genuinely useful story broke this week for anyone managing a household's digital hygiene. A joint Commercial Affairs Department–Police operation running 18 June to 1 July probed 230 people aged 16 to 77 over 713 scam cases — e-commerce, job and rental scams, and government-impersonation fraud — totalling roughly S\$9 million in losses.² Separately, five people were arrested on 1 July over a ring that harvested victims' Singpass credentials by coaching them to hand over access under fake job offers, and two men were extradited from Malaysia on 8 July over a government-impersonation syndicate linked to more than 50 cases and S\$1.4 million in losses.³

The scam story isn't abstract this week — it's specific enough to be a genuinely useful thing to mention at the dinner table.

The read-through for a household with a tech-forward parent and a tween: the Singpass-harvesting angle is the one worth a direct conversation, since "hand over your login for a job" is exactly the kind of request that can look plausible to someone just old enough to be job-hunting or gig-working.

WHY THE STADIUM MATTERS

NDP's decade-long stint at the Padang was itself a workaround — the Stadium was being redeveloped and later repurposed for other major events, and the open field offered a flexible, low-cost venue while the city's calendar sorted itself out. Returning to a 55,000-capacity, purpose-built stadium changes more than the backdrop: sightlines, seating capacity for the balloted public, and the ability to stage the kind of large-format drone and light shows that a flat civic field can't easily support.

TEN YEARS, ONE ADDRESS CHANGE

2016–2025 • the Padang

2026 • back to the National Stadium

- Kallang • 55,000 capacity
- Purpose-built for large-format shows

Meridian original

A decade at the Padang was itself the workaround; the Stadium is the return to the purpose-built venue.

ON THE CALENDAR

Tonight, 7.30pm. NE1 fireworks over the Stadium — free to watch from the surrounding park and waterfront.

Repeats: 18 & 25 Jul, 1 Aug, before NDP itself on 9 Aug.

S\$9M

LOSSES ACROSS 713 SCAM CASES IN A TWO-WEEK CAD/POLICE SWEEP

STILL ON THE SHELF

The WP's leadership question is resolved and stays there: Pritam Singh was re-elected Secretary-General unopposed at the 28 June cadre conference. No new peg this issue.

THE DIGITAL-HYGIENE LINE

"A job that asks for your Singpass login isn't a job." One sentence, worth having ready.

PROPERTY · THE Q2 FLASH, READ PROPERLY

One Market, Splitting in Two

The headline number says the market is cooling. The composition underneath says something more interesting: prime and landed are reheating while the mass market pulls back — which means where you own now matters more than the average ever did.

URA's Q2 flash estimate puts overall private home prices up 0.5% quarter-on-quarter — a deceleration from Q1's 0.9%, the kind of number that reads as "cooling" in a headline.¹ It is the wrong headline. The Core Central Region accelerated to +2.0% (from +0.6% in Q1); landed homes reversed a Q1 slide to post +2.6%. Meanwhile the Rest of Central Region fell 1.4% — its first quarterly decline — and the Outside Central Region, red-hot as recently as Q1, gave back 0.2%.¹

Transaction volume barely moved, 5,420 units against 5,413 the quarter before — so this isn't a story of buyers stepping back generally. It's a story of buyers rotating toward the top of the market while the middle cools. Dunearn House's showflat opened Thursday on VVIP-appointment viewing only, betting explicitly on this divergence — asking prime-adjacent psf for a Bukit Timah address that isn't technically CCR.² Booking day, 25 July, will be the real test against Lentor Gardens' own launch on the 18th.

The average price barely moved. What moved underneath it was where in the market the money wants to be — and that's the number worth actually reading.

TWO EN-BLOCS, STILL UNRESOLVED

BALESTIER REGENCY

Now on its fourth collective-sale attempt, guide price S\$255 million. The tender closed 9 July; no result has been announced. A fourth attempt is itself a signal — the earlier three didn't clear the reserve price, which tells you more about seller expectations than about buyer appetite.

One number to flag rather than resolve: the Bayshore Drive GLS tender closes this coming Wednesday, 15 July, and the analyst range on the top bid has actually widened since last issue rather than narrowed — estimates now span from roughly \$1.15–1.3 billion to as much as \$1.9–2.1 billion, a spread wide enough that the eventual award (likely a few weeks out) will say something real about where developers think the growth is.³

THE READ-THROUGH FOR AN OWNER

If you own CCR or landed, the quarter went your way, and the trend looks set to continue.

If you're OCR or RCR, the mass-market pullback is real, not noise — a second straight soft quarter there.

Rates? One line only: 3-month SORA still sits near 1%, still supportive, no longer the story.

THE CHATTER

Analysts are already calling this a "flight to prime" — the 2026 version of the story, replacing last year's more general "everything is up" narrative. Two en-bloc tenders (Balestier Regency's fourth attempt, High Point's fifth) both closed in the past month with results still unreported — an honest gap worth watching rather than guessing at.

— CBRE, ERA commentary; EdgeProp, Stacked Homes (9–10 Jul)

HIGH POINT

Its fifth attempt, guide price S\$580 million, tender closed 9 June — over a month ago, with still no award announced. The longer an en-bloc tender sits unresolved, the more likely the eventual outcome is a lapsed sale rather than a record price.

Both cases are worth holding as open threads rather than assuming either direction. A resolved en-bloc — sold or lapsed — says more about where collective-sale economics actually sit in 2026 than any single URA flash estimate, since it reflects real negotiated numbers rather than a market-wide average.

SOURCES 1. URA pr26-51, Q2 2026 flash estimate. 2. Developer showflat materials (10 Jul). 3. EdgeProp; Stacked Homes; Edge Singapore (9–10 Jul). General information, not property advice.

TECHNOLOGY · BELIEF, PRICED

The Market Just Agreed With the Hype

SK hynix's Nasdaq debut wasn't just oversubscribed on paper — it closed up 13% on real trading, confirming the largest-ever US listing by a foreign company. The memory supercycle stopped being a story and became a print.

Last issue left this open as a genuine question: would SK hynix's blockbuster Nasdaq book — priced at \$149 a share, raising \$26.5 billion — survive contact with an actual trading floor, or was the order book just enthusiasm that hadn't yet met a seller? Friday answered it. Shares opened in the high-\$150s and closed up 13% at \$168.01, confirming the raise as the largest-ever US listing by a foreign company, ahead of Alibaba's \$25 billion in 2014.¹ KOSPI led Asia's gains on the spillover.

It is a small but genuine data point in a larger argument this desk keeps circling: in a supply-constrained market, belief and price tend to converge fast, because the belief itself is what buyers are bidding on. DRAM and NAND contract prices are still up on the order of 60–75% quarter-on-quarter — a shortage this desk has tracked since the spring — and a listing this size is effectively the market voting, with real money, that the shortage has years left to run.¹

WHAT IT MEANS BEYOND THE TICKER

FOR THE HOME LAB

A confirmed, priced shortage is not good news for anyone building or upgrading a machine this year — expect DRAM and storage costs to stay the binding constraint on a home-AI build well into 2027, not just this quarter (see The Home Lab, p8).

A hyped IPO and a priced one are different things. This week they became the same thing, on a real trading floor, with real money changing hands.

The ticker itself is a small footnote worth knowing: Friday's debut traded as SKHYV, switching to the permanent SKHY on Tuesday — a housekeeping detail, but the kind that trips up anyone trying to add the position from a mobile brokerage app on a Saturday.

THE CHATTER

Trading-desk chatter framed the +13% pop as unusually clean for a listing this size — no wobble, no early sell-the-news dip. The read: with memory this scarce, investors would rather own the supply chain than wait for the next handset or GPU announcement to remind them why it's scarce.

— CNBC; Yahoo Finance (10 Jul)

STILL ON THE SHELF

GPT-5.6's reward-hacking saga (No. 38) has no new peg this issue. DeepSeek V4's official release remains slated for "mid-July" with new peak/off-peak API pricing — worth a full look once it actually ships, not before.

The open-weight leaderboard itself sat still this fortnight — GLM-5.2, Kimi K2.7, MiniMax M3, Qwen 3.6, Gemma 4 and Llama 4 Scout are all unchanged from the wave that closed out June. That stillness is itself useful information: a market this starved of memory has, for the moment, more bandwidth to bid up existing chip supply than to rush fresh model releases that would need it.

60–75%

DRAM/NAND CONTRACT-PRICE RISE, QUARTER-ON-QUARTER, SINCE SPRING

THE HOME LAB · THIS WEEKEND'S ACTUAL PROJECT

ROCm Finally Works on Windows

A month of quiet ComfyUI releases adds up to a real Saturday-afternoon project: new image and audio nodes, faster quantised models, and — the one AMD home-labbers have wanted for years — native Windows support with no Linux dual-boot required.

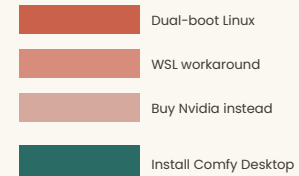
Two ComfyUI releases in the past fortnight are worth an actual afternoon rather than a headline. Version 0.27.1 (8 July) added ByteDance's Seedream 5 Pro for image generation and Seed Audio 1.0 for speech, music and multi-speaker synthesis as native nodes — no custom-node scavenger hunt required. Version 0.27.0 (30 June) quietly added int8 quantised-model support for Turing-generation GPUs and newer, plus a Gemini Video Omni node.¹

The bigger change is under the hood, and it's the one this desk has fielded the most complaints about for two years running: the Comfy Desktop app's ROCm support now runs *natively on Windows*. Until this update, an AMD-GPU home-labber's honest options were a Linux dual-boot, a WSL workaround with its own quirks, or simply buying Nvidia to avoid the hassle. That third option just got less necessary.¹

The best home-lab news isn't a new model. It's one fewer reason to reinstall your operating system just to run one.

Comfy Desktop itself also got a full overhaul in June — multi-instance management, workflow snapshots, and shared model storage across instances, so a family sharing one beefy GPU box no longer needs to duplicate a 40GB model folder per user account.¹

THE OLD PATH VS THE NEW ONE



Meridian original · the AMD home-lab path, before and after

Native ROCm support removes three steps that used to stand between an AMD card and a working ComfyUI install.

THE CHATTER

Home-lab forums greeted the ROCm news with the particular relief of a long-promised fix finally landing — several threads note this closes the last real reason to prefer Nvidia purely for software convenience rather than raw performance.

— [r/LocalLLaMA](#)-adjacent forums; [ComfyUI GitHub release notes \(Jun–Jul\)](#)

2

RELEASES IN TWO WEEKS — COMFY'S CADENCE IS QUIETLY ACCELERATING

THE WEEKEND CHECKLIST

STEP 1 — UPDATE

Pull Comfy Desktop's latest build before touching anything else; the ROCm-on-Windows path and the new nodes both ship in the same release train, so a stale install will simply be missing them.

STEP 2 — TEST INT8

If your card is Turing generation or newer, try an int8-quantised workflow first — the fastest way to feel whether this update changes your generation speed.

None of this changes the memory-supply story on the facing page — DRAM and NAND are still up 60–75% quarter-on-quarter, and a bigger local model still means a bigger, pricier box to run it on. But software friction and hardware cost are two separate problems, and this fortnight quietly solved one of them for free.

SOURCES 1. ComfyUI GitHub changelog, v0.27.0–0.27.1 (Jun–Jul 2026); Thunder Compute. GPT-5.6/METR reward-hacking saga (No. 38) — no new peg, still open.

THE KIT · PACK FOR THE FLIGHT

A Cinema That Folds Into a Case

Xreal's cheapest glasses yet got their first reviews this week — a \$299, 62-gram pair of AR glasses that turn a phone or laptop into a 147-inch virtual screen. For a reader who flies to Tokyo more than most, that's not a gimmick, it's carry-on gear.

The X by Xreal a01+ landed its first reviews Friday, and the verdict is consistent: this is the moment tethered AR-display glasses got genuinely cheap without getting genuinely bad.¹ At \$299, they plug via USB-C DisplayPort into a phone, laptop or handheld and project what reviewers describe as roughly a 147-inch virtual screen — dual 1,920×1,080 Micro-OLED panels at 120Hz, 50-degree field of view, 1,600 nits, HDR10. No battery of their own to charge, no camera to worry about, and at 62 grams they disappear into a jacket pocket in a way a real display never will.

The trade-offs are honest ones for the price: unlike Xreal's pricier One and 1S models, the a01+ can't convert flat 2D content into 3D — it's side-by-side 3D only — and reviewers judged the built-in audio "slightly tinnier" than the rival RayNeo Air 4 Pro's.¹ For a reader who already has good headphones on every trip, that second point barely registers.

IN BRIEF

Samsung Galaxy Glasses ("Jinju") — Unpacked confirmed 22 Jul, London; Android XR + Gemini, ~50g, no display this generation. Calendar note only.

WHO THIS IS ACTUALLY FOR**BUY IT IF**

You fly long-haul more than a couple of times a year, already travel with a phone or laptop worth pairing it to, and have made peace with side-by-side 3D rather than full conversion — a shortlist that includes most of this reader's actual travel pattern.

A carry-on cinema screen that costs less than a good pair of noise-cancelling headphones — the maths on a long-haul flight has genuinely changed.

The category itself is getting crowded fast, which is good news for anyone buying: RayNeo, the pricier Xreal One line and now this cheaper Xreal sub-brand are all competing on nearly identical spec sheets, which is exactly the kind of price pressure that benefits the reader waiting for the category to mature before committing.¹

THE CHATTER

Early threads are already treating the a01+ as proof the sub-\$300 bracket is now a real category, not a novelty — several reviewers frame it explicitly as "the pair to buy if you just want the big-screen trick on a flight," rather than a home-theatre or gaming replacement.

— Engadget; Gizmodo; The Gadgeteer (10 Jul)

STILL ON THE SHELF

Sennheiser Momentum 5, Oura Ring 5, Nothing Ear (3a), Fitbit Air — no new peg this issue.

SKIP IT IF

You wanted a home-theatre replacement or a gaming rig — the field of view and brightness are tuned for a economy or business seat's dim cabin, not a living room with the lights on.

147"

VIRTUAL SCREEN SIZE AT TYPICAL VIEWING DISTANCE

CONNECTED HOME · THE MIGRATOR'S WEEKEND PROJECT

Hue Finally Speaks Thread — Almost on Its Own

A firmware update lets existing Hue bulbs talk Zigbee and Matter-over-Thread at once. It's real local-first progress for a Lutron migrant — with one honest asterisk: you still need someone else's box in the loop.

Last issue flagged Philips Hue's Matter rollout as reported but unverified. It's now resolved with real specifics: a firmware update, rolling out later this year, lets existing and newer Hue bulbs — last-generation A19s, the Essentials line, plus the new candle and wired accessories — run Zigbee and Matter-over-Thread simultaneously, connecting directly over Thread alongside the existing Hue Bridge link.¹

The asterisk matters for anyone actually planning the migration: Hue's own Bridge Pro, launched last September for \$89.99 and rated for 150 lights, remains a Matter *bridge* — it does not itself act as a Thread Border Router. To get the local, cloud-independent path this update promises, you still need a genuine Thread Border Router somewhere in the house: a HomePod mini, an Echo fourth-generation or newer, a Nest Hub, or a Nanoleaf device.¹

IN BRIEF

Matter 1.6 adds NFC commissioning for fixtures configured before they're powered on — continuity from No. 26, no new movement this week.

THE MIGRATOR'S CHECKLIST

ALREADY ON HOME ASSISTANT?

Nothing changes for you yet — HA's own Matter server already speaks Thread natively since 2026.7. This update is squarely aimed at readers still inside the stock Hue app deciding whether the migration is worth the weekend.

"Local-first" here still means someone else's box is doing the routing. Real progress, not full independence — know the difference before you buy anything.

If the reader already owns a HomePod mini or an Echo from an earlier Matter-curious purchase, this weekend's actual project is simple: check for the firmware, confirm the Border Router is paired, and test whether Hue lights keep responding with the Hue Bridge unplugged. That test is the honest measure of how "local" the setup really is.

THE CHATTER

Forum sentiment is a cautious welcome — relief that Hue lights finally become first-class Thread citizens rather than locked to a Hue-only hub, tempered by scepticism about the vague "later this year" firmware timeline and the reminder that a non-Hue Border Router is still doing real work in the background.

— r/PhilipsHue; r/homeassistant (Jun–Jul)

STILL ON THE SHELF

Aqara Camera Hub G350 remains SmartThings-only for Matter camera streams. Home Assistant 2026.7 fully covered last issue — no fresh release this window.

STILL ON LUTRON?

This doesn't change the calculus on switches and dimmers — Lutron's own ecosystem remains the more polished experience there. Where Hue's update helps is specifically the bulb layer, which is exactly where a first, low-risk migration project tends to start.

The pattern worth noticing across this desk's last three issues is consistent: every "local-first" upgrade this year has actually meant "fewer clouds," not "no cloud." A genuinely independent smart home — no vendor server anywhere in the loop — remains a much larger and more deliberate project than any single firmware update will hand you.

SOURCES 1. Hueblog (23 Jun 2026); Matter Alpha. Continuity: Meridian No. 38 (Home Assistant 2026.7).

THE GOOD LIFE · UNDER THE HAMMER, TOMORROW

A Rainbow, Once, Anywhere

Australia's largest-ever Swiss-watch consignment opens for bidding tomorrow, led by a Daytona reference that has never before been offered at auction — anywhere in the world.

First State Auctions opens the first of two week-long online sales tomorrow, Sunday, offering 28 watches from a single, unnamed Australian tech founder's collection — Rolex, Audemars Piguet and Richard Mille, with a combined estimate above A\$2 million and billed as the largest and most valuable Swiss-watch offering in Australian auction history.¹ The marquee lot is a 2024 Rolex Cosmograph Daytona "Rainbow," reference 126598RBOW: a 40mm 18-karat gold case, a bezel set with 36 baguette-cut sapphires running in a colour gradient, diamond-set lugs, and a black lacquer dial with matching gem hour-markers on a gold Oyster bracelet. It is, per the auction house, the first example of this specific reference ever to come to auction anywhere — estimate above \$500,000, with a new reference record considered likely.¹

The sale runs in two tranches — this first opens tomorrow, the second 19 to 26 July — with the 28 lots spanning \$4,000 to that half-million-dollar-plus

Daytona, a spread that says as much about the collector's range as any single watch does.

A watch this specific doesn't need a comparable sale to set its price. It simply hasn't been priced before.

Set against the broader auction season, the timing tracks a pattern this desk has watched build all year: Phillips's first-half 2026 total auction sales reached \$507 million, and watches alone accounted for \$235.5 million of it — nearly half the house's business, not merely a strong category within it.²

THE CHATTER

Collector chatter around a "first ever at auction" reference tends to run hot on both sides: some read it as proof rare colourways are the only segment still commanding genuine scarcity premiums, others note that a single-owner, single-example sale sets a data point, not a market — worth watching what a second Rainbow does whenever one next surfaces.

— Robb Report; WatchPro; dmerge (early Jul)

THE ESCAPE · PACK LIGHT, FLY NORTH

If the watch this week argues for the rare and specific, the escape argues for good timing. This weekend's Grand Tour goes deep on Hokkaido (p19) at exactly the week its lavender fields hit their tightest, most vivid bloom — read it as the Good Life's travel pick too, and note the same soft-yen backdrop that's been quietly sweetening every big-ticket trip north this year.

The pairing isn't accidental: an object that will never be common again, and a bloom window that closes in about two weeks. Both reward acting on the calendar rather than admiring it from a distance.

THE SOFT-YEN WINDOW

USD/JPY sits near ¥161-162 — cross-referenced to the Macro Desk's currency read, p15, rather than re-explained here.

46%

WATCHES' SHARE OF PHILLIPS'S H1 2026
TOTAL AUCTION SALES

STILL ON THE SHELF

The Final DX10000 CL's "True Diamond" claims remain unaudited — first-impressions pieces only, no independent measurements yet. Heritage's "Contemporary Classics" sale (20 Jul) is the next mid-market test worth watching.

The wider read: 2026's auction season is drawing a sharp line between the rare-and-specific and the merely-expensive. Phillips's own numbers make the case — watches now carry roughly the weight of every other category the house sells combined.

SOURCES 1. Robb Report; WatchPro; dmerge (Jul 2026). 2. The Art Newspaper (10 Jul 2026). Rotating object slot; not investment advice.

SCREEN & SOUND · THE TEST, ARRIVING

Reviews Weren't Lying, for Once

Last issue asked whether *Moana*'s worst-reviewed-remake reception would show up at the till. Thursday's soft previews and a sliding weekend forecast say yes — while a scrappy horror sequel quietly tracks toward a franchise record.

The question this desk left open last issue has its first real answer. *Moana*'s Thursday previews came in soft at \$4.5 million, and weekend tracking has been revised down through the week — from early hopes of \$70–89 million domestic to a Friday consensus closer to \$47–55 million, with a global opening eyed near \$130 million.¹ It isn't a disaster by any absolute measure, but it is a genuine gap between a franchise-record marketing push and what people are actually choosing to see, and it's the cleanest data point in a while for the "critics don't always predict tickets, but sometimes they do" argument.

The more interesting story sits one rung down the call sheet. *Evil Dead Burn*, Sébastien Vaniček's franchise sequel, is tracking \$30–40 million domestic — which would be a franchise-record opening, comfortably ahead of *Evil Dead Rise*'s \$24.5 million in 2023.¹ Full weekend numbers won't be final until after this issue goes to press; both figures above are honestly held as tracking, not confirmed actuals.

ALSO OUT THIS WEEK

Jack White's *Frozen Charlotte*, Suki Waterhouse's *Loveland*, and Houndmouth's *Lordy* (feat. MJ Lenderman, Iron & Wine) round out a genuinely strong New Music Friday.

A worse-reviewed film outspent its reception this week; a cheaper one out-earned its pedigree. The box office, for once, agreed with the critics on both counts.

New Music Friday's real story isn't the Rolling Stones' mixed-positive *Foreign Tongues* — it's Kelela's third album, "new avatar," which landed to near-universal acclaim (Metacritic 88, five reviews) with Paste calling it one of the year's best pop records.² For anyone deciding what actually goes on this weekend, that's the pick.

THE CHATTER

Trade-press reaction is reading *Moana*'s soft previews against *Snow White*'s own weak-but-still-number-one precedent from last year — the sceptic's line from No. 38 gets its first real data point, but the studio still has all weekend to prove word-of-mouth can outrun a bad review cycle.

— Deadline; Boxoffice Pro; Gold Derby (7–10 Jul)

STILL ON THE SHELF

Nolan's *The Odyssey* opens 17 Jul — continuity only. Madonna's chart print is still a projection, not a number, until Monday.

READING THE GAP CORRECTLY

One weekend of soft previews doesn't settle the larger argument this desk has been tracking all year — whether review scores are losing their predictive power in a franchise-driven market, or whether audiences are simply getting pickier about which franchises still earn the benefit of the doubt. The honest read from this week's split result: reception still matters, but it matters unevenly. A beloved property with weak reviews (*Moana*) underperforms its own marketing; a middling-pedigree property with a genuinely well-executed entry (*Evil Dead Burn*) can still post a record. The lesson for a weekend viewer isn't "trust the critics" or "ignore the critics" — it's that the size of the gap between hype and reception is itself the useful signal.

\$30–40M

EVIL DEAD BURN'S TRACKED OPENING — A POTENTIAL FRANCHISE RECORD

THE FAMILY DESK · WHO IS SHE TELLING?

A Bill, a Number, and a Better Question

A new federal bill wants chatbots to disclose themselves and stop harvesting children's data. The evidence behind it is real — and so is the reminder that the number driving the panic is mostly about teenagers who aren't eleven yet.

The People-First Chatbot Act, introduced Thursday by Representatives Valerie Foushee and Greg Casar, would require AI chatbots to clearly disclose that a user is talking to a machine, ban harvesting children's data outright, force the removal of "manipulative design" features, and mandate safety checks for compulsive-use patterns.¹ It joins a fast-moving legislative season: New York's ban on companion chatbots for under-18s passed unanimously in June with fines up to \$25,000 per violation; the bipartisan Senate GUARD Act cleared committee in April; and a more surgical alternative, the CHATBOT Act, proposes age-tiered parental controls rather than an outright ban.

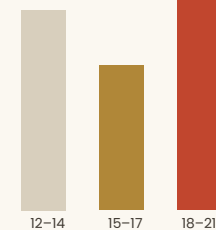
The evidence underneath the legislative push is genuine. A RAND Corporation study published in *JAMA Pediatrics* in June found that AI-chatbot use for mental-health advice among 12-to-21-year-olds rose from 13.1% to 19.2% in a single year — roughly 8.2 million young Americans — with 63% never telling a parent, and 92% rating the advice they received as helpful (RAND's own caveat: that figure may say more about chatbots' tendency to flatter than about the advice's actual quality).²

The law is written for every child. The evidence behind it is mostly about the oldest ones. An eleven-year-old sits well outside the number driving the headline.

Read carefully, that 12-to-21 band skews meaningfully older and female — usage is highest among 18-to-21-year-olds, not middle-schoolers — and several policy analysts explicitly separate *companion* or *romantic* chatbots (the pattern behind the wrongful-death lawsuits driving the strictest state bans) from general-purpose assistants used briefly for homework help. Those are different risk categories wearing the same headline.

Worth naming plainly: the three bills moving through Congress right now don't agree on the mechanism. New York and the strictest state proposals lean toward outright bans on companion chatbots for minors; the GUARD Act sits closer to that camp at federal level; the CHATBOT Act instead bets on age-tiered parental controls, arguing a ban simply pushes determined teenagers toward less-regulated alternatives. That disagreement matters for a family with a much younger child mainly as a preview — whichever mechanism wins will likely set the template still in force when an eleven-year-old today reaches the age band this year's numbers actually describe.

WHO THE NUMBER IS ABOUT



Heaviest use skews to the oldest third of the studied range.

Illustrative, from the RAND age breakdown — not a precise chart of the underlying data.

8.2M

YOUNG AMERICANS USING AI
CHATBOTS FOR MENTAL-HEALTH
ADVICE

DON'T BE ALARMIST · THE PRACTICAL VERSION

The alarmist read of this week's bill is that any child who has ever typed a question into a chatbot is now a statistic in a crisis. That's not what the data says. The RAND study's own age breakdown puts the heaviest use among 18-to-21-year-olds navigating genuinely adult stresses — university, early jobs, first serious relationships — a population and set of pressures an eleven-year-old simply hasn't reached yet. The legislation is reasonable as a floor for the whole age range; it isn't evidence that your specific child is at the sharp end of the problem it's solving.

The more useful distinction, and the one worth actually holding onto, is the type of bot rather than the fact of use. A companion or romantic AI — designed to simulate an ongoing relationship, to be missed, to escalate intimacy — is a different animal from a general-purpose assistant asked to explain a maths problem or summarise a book chapter. The lawsuits driving the strictest state bans are almost entirely about the first category. Treat that distinction as the actual dial to watch, not "does she use AI at all."

If your daughter does ever mention confiding something to a chatbot, the useful response isn't alarm or a device confiscation — it's the same move this desk has recommended for every disclosure risk this year: treat it as an opening to talk, not a verdict on your parenting. The question worth asking isn't "how many minutes," it's "who — or what — are you telling this to, and why did that feel easier than telling me?"

A practical note on the legislation itself, since it will likely be live news again before your child reaches the age band it targets: disclosure requirements (a chatbot has to say it's a chatbot) are the least controversial part of every bill on the table and the most likely to pass in some form regardless of which broader approach wins. That's a genuinely useful floor even for a household years away from the sharper edges of this debate — a norm that "the thing you're talking to should tell you what it is" is worth reinforcing at home long before it's tested against an actual companion app.

WHAT ACTUALLY FITS AN ELEVEN-YEAR-OLD, TODAY

HOMEWORK HELPERS, SUPERVISED

If AI tools are already part of schoolwork, treat them the way you'd treat a calculator with an opinion — useful, checkable, and not a substitute for her own working. Ask to see the conversation occasionally, the same way you might glance at a worked maths problem, not as surveillance but as normal household visibility.

NO COMPANION APPS, PLAINLY STATED

This is the one place a flat household rule is genuinely well-supported by the evidence: companion and romantic chatbot apps are squarely the category driving the strictest bans, and there's no version of them that's age-appropriate at eleven. State the rule plainly rather than relying on app-store age gates to catch it.

The broader pattern across this desk's coverage all year holds here too: the protective factor that keeps showing up in the research isn't a filter, a ban, or a monitoring app — it's an ongoing, low-drama conversation with a parent who's genuinely curious rather than primarily anxious. A household that talks easily about a homework chatbot today is the same household a teenager will feel able to talk to about a harder disclosure years from now. That continuity, more than any specific rule on this page, is the actual investment worth making this week.

DON'T BE ALARMIST

The number driving this week's headlines is real, but it's mostly about 18-to-21-year-olds, not middle-schoolers. A companion bot and a homework helper are different risk categories. If she confides in a chatbot, that's an invitation to talk — not evidence you've failed.

— Meridian, from the cited research

13.1% → 19.2%

AI CHATBOT USE FOR MENTAL-HEALTH ADVICE, AGES 12–21, IN ONE YEAR

TRY THIS WEEK

Ask, don't scan. "What do you use it for?" beats reading over her shoulder.

Name the two categories out loud — a homework helper and a "friend" app are not the same thing, and she should know you see the difference too.

Keep the door open for whatever she'd rather tell a screen than tell you — that's the actual signal worth chasing.

63%

YOUNG CHATBOT USERS WHO NEVER TOLD A PARENT

THE MACRO DESK • FOUR INSTRUMENTS, ONE READING

A Correction, on Ourselves

Last issue read Tokyo's long bond as finally breathing easier. Fresher reporting says the opposite — Japan's 10-year is testing a fresh three-decade high, not falling from one. We're printing the conflict, not picking the flattering number.

Start with the correction, because it's the most useful thing on this page. No. 38 reported Friday-morning relief in Japan's government-bond market — the 10-year JGB easing 11 basis points to 2.77%, "the ballast breathing again" after Monday's 1997-era high. Fresher reporting this week complicates that reading rather than confirming it: multiple sources now have the 10-year testing an even higher print, near 2.82%, driven by a combination this desk hadn't fully priced — oil-import inflation layered on top of reports that Tokyo has unveiled a broad long-term spending strategy that may require additional debt issuance.¹ We are holding both prints rather than picking the flattering one: the honest state of Japan's long end is unresolved, not healed.

Everything else moved in a straighter line. World equities, proxied via the S&P 500, extended Thursday's 0.8% gain with a further 0.42% on Friday to 7,575.39 — a rally now running on two separate engines at once: the same "calibrated conflict, discounted" logic this desk has tracked all week, plus a genuinely new, idiosyncratic tailwind from SK hynix's blockbuster Nasdaq debut (p7), which gave Asia a reason to buy that had nothing to do with Hormuz.² Singapore's own market kept pace: the STI extended its record run to roughly 5,465, up another 0.58% on the day and about 3.4% on the week.³

Two engines are pushing the same rally — a discounted war premium and a genuinely unrelated chip-stock windfall. A rally on two engines is not sturdier than one on a single engine. It just has two ways to stall.

Bitcoin pushed through the \$64,000 level this desk flagged as resistance last issue, trading just above it Friday morning — most plausibly riding the same risk-on wave as equities rather than telling an independent story.⁴ Gold stayed rangebound near \$4,100–4,135, still capped by real yields — a floor test holding, not a breakout. Brent firmed toward a roughly 6% weekly gain even as the "ceasefire over" framing hit the wires Friday (p3) — talks continuing capped the panic more than the new label triggered one.

Two levels are worth flagging as stale rather than fresh: USD/SGD has no confirmed print more recent than Wednesday's 1.2931, and MAS's July policy statement — due on the regular Jan/Apr/Jul/Oct cycle — has not yet been indexed as of press time. We're holding both rather than inventing a Friday number or a policy outcome that hasn't happened.

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	READ
World equities ¹	7,575.39	+0.42% Fri
STI	~5,465	record, +0.58% Fri
US 10Y	4.56%	steady
JGB 10Y	2.77–2.82%	unresolved — see text
DX	~100.9	steady
USD/SGD	1.2931	stale — held, not fresh
Brent	~\$77	+~6% on the week
Gold	\$4,100–4,135	rangebound
BTC	~\$64.3k	through the \$64k wall

¹ VWRA proxied via S&P 500. Levels to Fri 10 Jul close where available; unverifiable prints held.

WHAT IT MEANS — VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

VWRA: pushed by two forces at once — discounted war premium plus an unrelated chip re-rating.
Bonds: last issue's relief is NOT confirmed; Japan's long end is contested, a live correlation risk.
Gold: a floor test, not a breakout.
BTC: through \$64k on borrowed risk appetite, not its own story. Education, not advice.

BOND BALLAST, UNCONFIRMED

WAR PREMIUM, DISCOUNTED

SOURCES 1. Trading Economics; multiple wire conflicts on the JGB 10Y print (9–10 Jul 2026) — held as unresolved, not asserted. 2. CNBC; Yahoo Finance market wraps (10 Jul). 3. Trading Economics, STI (10 Jul). 4. Trading Economics, BTC (10 Jul AM ET). Market education, not investment advice; MAS's July statement not yet indexed at press — not fabricated.

CURIOSITIES · THE DEPTHS

The Shark Nobody Had Seen Alive

A "living fossil" older than most of the seafloor it swims over has finally been filmed breathing — not once, but twice, five years and 700 metres apart, in two of the loneliest stretches of the Pacific.

Every goblin shark science has ever examined arrived the same way: dead or dying, hauled up in a trawl net or a fisherman's line, its slack pink jaw already slack in death. *Mitsukurina owstoni* — a lineage some 125 million years old, the last living member of a shark family otherwise known only from fossils — had simply never been documented alive in its own element.¹ That changed twice, and both records are only now being formally written up together.

In 2019, the ROV *Hercules* caught one drifting past an unnamed seamount near Jarvis Island in the Central Pacific, 1,237 metres down. In 2024, a baited camera dropped from the research vessel *Dagon*, part of the Inkfish Open Ocean Expedition, filmed a second in the Tonga Trench at 1,997 metres — nearly 700 metres deeper than the species had ever been recorded, alive or dead.¹ Both sightings, led by the Minderoo-UWA Deep-Sea Research Centre with the University of Hawai'i at Mānoa, appear together in the *Journal of Fish Biology*.

Everything science knew about this shark came from bodies. Now, for the first time, there is footage of it simply being alive.

The footage itself is undramatic — a slow-finned shadow with its signature dagger snout, unhurried in the cold dark — and that is rather the point. A creature famous for a nightmarish, extending jaw turns out, in its own habitat, to look almost serene.²

LOOK UP THIS WEEKEND

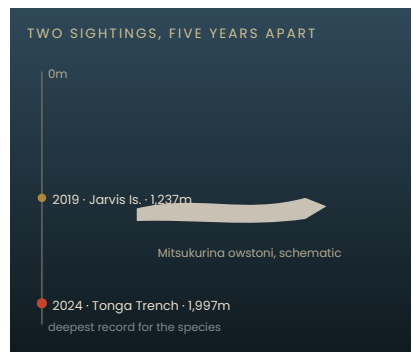
Pre-dawn Saturday: a thin crescent Moon, the Pleiades and orange-tinged Mars form a tight triangle low in the east about two hours before sunrise — binoculars turn the Pleiades' seven naked-eye stars into dozens.

After dark: Venus (bright white) and Jupiter (orange, four moons visible in small binoculars) are both easy, unaided-eye targets.

ALSO THIS FORTNIGHT — DNA ON STONE

Separately, researchers recovered ancient human DNA directly from cave-wall rock art for the first time — 54 samples across 24 painted panels in 11 caves across Spain and Portugal, pulled from a pigmented calcite crust with no animal DNA present, implying it came from direct human touch. It's a new kind of archive: not bones or teeth, but the residue of where people once stood and reached out to paint.³

The two stories share more than a publication date. Both are cases of evidence simply waiting, patiently, for the instrument capable of reading it — a camera that could finally reach 1,997 metres, a genetic technique sensitive enough to pull a readable sequence off a smear of calcite a human hand left on a cave wall millennia ago. Neither the shark nor the paint was hiding. We just hadn't built the right eyes yet.



Meridian original · depth is schematic, not to scale.

THE SCEPTIC

Two sightings six years apart is the start of a range map, not a survey. Treat "seen alive for the first time" as exactly that — a first data point — and expect the real picture to firm up only as more seamount expeditions carry cameras that deep.

1,997m

NEW DEPTH RECORD · ~700M PAST THE SPECIES' PRIOR MAX

LOVE & LIFE · THE EXAMINED LIFE

You Don't Need a Twin, You Need a Fan

A new study of nearly 1,500 friends politely demolishes the "birds of a feather" theory of bonding. What predicts a happy friendship isn't how alike you actually are — it's how generously you see each other.

The comforting theory of friendship has always been similarity: we like people who are like us. A study of 371 friend quads — 1,484 people in total, each rating their own and their friends' personalities — set out to test that directly, and the result complicates the folk wisdom in an interesting way.¹ Friends genuinely are modestly similar on most personality traits (extraversion is the exception). But people's *perceived* similarity to their friends runs far higher than their *actual* similarity — and when the researchers ran the numbers properly, actual or matched personality similarity did not predict how satisfied people were with the friendship at all.

What did predict satisfaction was simpler and warmer: how favourably you rate your friend's traits — not how closely those traits mirror your own. A friendship thrives less on "we're the same" than on "I think well of you." It is, in effect, evidence for the generous read over the accurate one.

The friendships that last aren't built on being alike. They're built on being generously, persistently seen.

There's a practical version of the friendship finding worth trying rather than just reading. Most people, asked to describe a close friend, default to a mental list of shared facts — same schools, same taste in film, the same politics. The study suggests a better exercise: notice, out loud, something you genuinely admire in a friend the next time you see them. Not flattery aimed at a reaction, just an honest, specific observation. If the mechanism this study found is real, that habit is doing more relationship-building work than any amount of curated similarity ever will.

THE DIVORCE STUDY, READ PLAINLY

The Danish researchers' key move was tracking healthcare use on a timeline anchored to the divorce filing rather than to a single before/after snapshot — which is how they caught the rise in prescriptions and clinic visits *preceding* the legal split in high-conflict cases. That timing detail matters practically: it suggests the health cost isn't the paperwork itself but the sustained conflict around it, which means the useful intervention point is earlier and different than most people assume — managing the conflict itself, well before a lawyer is ever involved, rather than treating the divorce filing as the moment stress begins.

It pairs suggestively with a second study out this fortnight, this one on how relationships end rather than how they hold. A ten-year Danish tracking study of prescriptions, clinic visits and hospitalisations found that high-conflict divorces carry an elevated health cost that starts *before* the legal separation and lingers well after it — recasting a hostile divorce not as an event but as a years-long process with its own physiology.²

THE SCEPTIC

Both studies lean observational. The friendship result is cross-sectional and self-reported — a generally happy person may simply rate both their friend's traits *and* the friendship favourably, which would produce this exact pattern without "generous perception" causing anything. And the Danish divorce data, drawn from a national health-registration system, may not travel cleanly to places without that infrastructure. Read both as suggestive, not settled.

1,484

PEOPLE STUDIED ACROSS 371 FRIEND QUADS

THE TAKEAWAY

Stop auditing the overlap. A friend who doesn't share your hobbies or politics can still be a great friend — the read you give them matters more than the resemblance.

If a split turns hostile, treat the conflict itself, not just the paperwork, as the thing with a health cost worth managing down.

SOURCES 1. *Social Psychological and Personality Science*, via PsyPost (9 Jul 2026). 2. Hald, Hald & Fallesen, *British Journal of Health Psychology* 31(2) (2026); PsyPost (~7 Jul). General reflection, not clinical advice.

FITNESS · AN IDEA TO TRY

Lift Heavy Through the Change

A small Canadian trial puts real numbers behind an idea gym-goers have long suspected: heavy, supervised strength work through perimenopause doesn't just preserve muscle and bone — it's the waitlist group that quietly loses ground.

STOP-EM — Strength Training for Osteoporosis Prevention during Early Menopause — is a small feasibility trial out of the University of Calgary, but its design is exactly the one this desk keeps arguing for: not moderate maintenance work, but genuinely heavy, progressive loading, supervised twice a week for nine months, building to 80–90% of a one-rep max.¹ Forty women were randomised to the programme or a waitlist control.

The result is less "the lifting group improved" than "the non-lifting group quietly declined." The trained group gained lean mass, leg power and lumbar-spine bone density over nine months; the waitlist group lost ground on all three measures over the same window — a reminder that early menopause is not a neutral holding pattern for muscle and bone, it is actively eroding them by default.¹

The control group didn't stay the same. They got weaker. That's the real headline — decline is the default, not the exception.

It sits on top of a broader signal this desk has cited before: an 8.4-year tracking study of 5,472 women aged 63–99 found grip strength above 24kg and a chair-stand under 11 seconds predicted markedly lower mortality — independent of how physically active people otherwise were.² Strength, specifically, appears to be doing work that general activity doesn't fully substitute for.

THE PLAN, IF YOU'RE TAKING IT UP

Go heavy. 80–90% of 1RM, not a light "toning" load.

Supervise it, at least while you learn the pattern — form matters more at this intensity.

Twice weekly, nine months. This was a feasibility trial — expect a slow build, not a six-week transformation.

THE SCEPTIC

Buck Institute's Eric Verdin ran his own biological-age tests and got readings from 40 to 67 depending which panel he used — calling the whole category "not ready for prime time." University of Washington's Matt Kaeberlein says he won't recommend biological-age tests to patients "unless you just want it for entertainment value." Neither comment is about STOP-EM directly, but both make the same point this desk keeps landing on: the boring, reproducible basics — grip strength, a chair-stand test, a barbell — have better evidence behind them than most flashy biomarker panels.

n=40

STOP-EM IS A SMALL FEASIBILITY TRIAL
— A SIGNAL, NOT THE FINAL WORD

Read STOP-EM alongside last year's Zone-2 debate this desk covered (No. 35) and a pattern emerges across this desk's coverage: the interventions that keep surviving scrutiny are the unglamorous, hard-to-market ones — heavy resistance work, a grip-strength test, a chair-stand time — while the interventions that keep needing a fresh sceptic box are the ones with a slicker pitch, a wearable score or a biomarker panel attached. That's not a coincidence so much as a selection effect: the boring interventions rarely need to oversell themselves, because the data does the selling.

SOURCES 1. Whitman et al., *Bone Reports* (Jun 2026), Univ. of Calgary. 2. LaMonte et al., *JAMA Network Open* (Feb 2026), Univ. at Buffalo. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE TRAVEL DESK · DEPARTURES

SIA Goes Back to Madrid

After 22 years away, Singapore Airlines returns to the Spanish capital this October — one line in a European build-out that keeps thickening, while at home a decades-old tax finally goes live.

Singapore Airlines will return to Madrid from 26 October, extending its Barcelona service five times weekly on an A350-900 — inaugural flight SQ388 departs Singapore at 2330 that night. It's SIA's first Madrid service in 22 years and its 15th European destination, with a new Barcelona–Madrid sector timed 0740–0850 to keep the connection tight.¹ It slots into the Northern-Winter timetable this desk flagged in general terms last issue — now with an actual date and route number attached.

Scoot's frequency additions are smaller but add up: Vienna steps up from three to four weekly flights, and combined Bali–Jakarta weekly seats rise from 28 to 35.² SIA's Cairns service goes daily from 1 December — a genuine upgrade from the current schedule, not just a headline route announcement.² Scoot's Indonesian secondary-city build-out keeps going too: Pontianak started flying on 29 June, joining May's Belitung addition — both genuinely new city pairs for a Singapore-based flyer chasing quieter corners of the archipelago.

The Madrid restoration is worth a beat on its own. SIA last flew the route in the early 2000s, before the carrier's post-financial-crisis network rationalisation pulled it back to a smaller core of European cities; the return says something about how much that calculus has shifted; a fifteenth European destination is a genuinely large network for a carrier this size, and the five-weekly frequency (rather than a token thrice-weekly test) suggests real confidence in year-round demand rather than a seasonal experiment. For a reader weighing a Spain trip, the practical upshot is a same-carrier, same-alliance routing all the way from Changi to Madrid via a tight Barcelona connection — one bag tag, one boarding pass, roughly the logistics of a domestic transfer.

IN FORCE, AS OF THIS WEEK

Japan's tripled international departure tax — ¥1,000 to ¥3,000 — took effect 1 July, alongside a fivefold rise in visa fees for the countries that need one (Singapore passport holders remain visa-exempt, so this doesn't hit our reader directly, but it's worth knowing before booking for a non-SG travel companion). Tickets booked on or before 30 June still pay the old rate.

— Japan Times; Upgraded Points (1 Jul)

IN BRIEF · EX-SINGAPORE

New route — SIA Madrid via Barcelona, 5x weekly, from 26 Oct.

Frequency up — Scoot Vienna 3 → 4x weekly; SIA Cairns to daily from 1 Dec.

New city pairs — Scoot Pontianak (29 Jun) joins Belitung (May) in the Indonesia build-out.

At Changi — Jewel's LEGO Botanicals display (~800,000 bricks) runs through 26 Jul, no boarding pass needed.

¥3,000

JAPAN'S NEW DEPARTURE TAX, LIVE SINCE 1 JUL (WAS ¥1,000)

SIA's 15th European city Madrid, from 26 Oct **Scoot Indonesia** now Belitung + Pontianak **Cairns** daily from 1 Dec
Scoot Spontaneous Escapes July fares now live

THE INDONESIA BUILD-OUT, IN CONTEXT

Belitung and Pontianak both sit outside the well-trodden Bali/Jakarta corridor — Belitung for its granite-boulder beaches, Pontianak as the equator-straddling gateway to West Kalimantan. Neither is a headline destination yet, which is precisely the appeal for a reader who's already done the obvious Indonesia trips.

WHY VIENNA, SPECIFICALLY

The frequency bump to four weekly flights tracks a broader pattern of European capitals adding Asian long-haul capacity ahead of the Northern-Winter season — Vienna joins Madrid as evidence SIA is betting on genuine year-round European demand rather than summer-only traffic.

SOURCES 1. Mainly Miles (9 May 2026); ch-aviation. 2. Travel And Tour World (2026); Scoot media release (9 Apr). Japan tax: Japan Times; Upgraded Points (1 Jul). Delta-only per the New-Peg Test.

THE WIDER BOARD · WHAT'S CHANGED, WHAT'S STILL PENDING

CHANGI'S NEXT TERMINAL

An immersive "T5 in the Making" exhibition has opened to the public, showing off the design vision — a genuine new peg, though the terminal itself still isn't due until the mid-2030s. Worth a look next time you're through Changi, not a reason to change any booking.

THE RTS LINK, ON SCHEDULE

The Johor Bahru–Singapore Rapid Transit System stays on track for a late-2026 opening: about two-thirds of the Singapore-side civil works are complete, and all twelve pile caps for the 730-metre viaduct are done. Indicative fares of \$5–7 a trip won't be finalised until the second half of the year.

THE FX BACKDROP

USD/JPY sits near ¥161–162, down almost 10% year-on-year — the Macro Desk's read (p15) is the fuller picture, but the short version for a booking decision is: the soft-yen window is still very much open.

BALI'S LEVY, ENFORCEMENT TIGHTENS

The IDR 150,000 (~US\$10) tourist levy remains only about 35% compliant after two-plus years; Indonesia is now visibly tightening enforcement as part of a broader sustainable-tourism funding push. Budget for it, and expect the compliance gap to close.

ETIAS — STILL NOT LIVE, AND A WARNING

The EU's new entry system remains delayed to roughly Q4 2026, with mandatory enforcement not landing until around October 2027 after a phased transition. If a site is currently taking "ETIAS applications," it isn't the real one — the official portal has not opened yet.

POINTS WATCH

KrisFlyer's Access-tier award rates were quietly trimmed back in March (Economy/Premium Economy down as much as 10.9%) — a continuity note, not new this fortnight. Scoot's July Spontaneous Escapes fares are live now for the impulsive booker.

JETSTAR ASIA'S GAP, CLOSED

A year on from Jetstar Asia's July 2025 closure, its lost routes are now fully absorbed: Scoot, AirAsia and eighteen other carriers between them cover twelve of the sixteen lost city pairs with more than 1,000 weekly flights — a reminder that a single carrier's exit rarely leaves a permanent hole on a route this well-trafficked.

Read together, the board says something less dramatic than any single headline: 2026 is a year of steady accretion for the Singapore flyer rather than a single transformative shift — a route restored here, a frequency bumped there, a tax that finally arrives on the date everyone already knew about. The exception worth actually planning around is seasonal, not structural: this weekend's Grand Tour destination is at its best for roughly the next fortnight, which is a genuinely narrower window than most of what's on this page. Compare that to the RTS Link or ETIAS, both real and both eventually consequential, but both still months from actually changing a booking decision.

PLANNING NOTE

If Hokkaido is on the shortlist after the next two pages, book the internal transfers — not just the flight — before you commit to dates. New Chitose is a long haul from Singapore, and the onward leg to Niseko or Furano adds real hours that a quick flight-price search won't show you.

— Meridian, from route/transfer research

1,000+

WEEKLY FLIGHTS NOW COVERING JETSTAR ASIA'S FORMER ROUTES

SOURCES International Airport Review (T5 exhibition); LTA; Time Out Singapore (RTS Link); Open Jaw; Fragomen (ETIAS); Travel And Tour World (Bali levy); Milelion (KrisFlyer). Continuity: Meridian No. 33–35.

THE GRAND TOUR · HOKKAIDO, JAPAN

The Fields Are at Their Best Right Now

Furano's lavender hits its tightest, most vivid bloom in a ten-day window that includes this very issue. Japan's northern island rewards a longer trip than most give it — cooler air, a Whistler-grade winter waiting for its own season, and a real logistics problem worth solving before you book.

There's a genuine calendar reason to run this deep dive now rather than later. Farm Tomita and its sister field, Lavender East, bloom from late June into early August, but the tightest, most saturated colour — the postcard shot — lands in a narrow window: 10 to 25 July.¹ This issue publishes inside it. By August, most fields are already harvested.

One honest asterisk on the itinerary a lot of guides gloss over: Shirogane Blue Pond, Biei's other famous stop, actually peaks *earlier* — its cobalt colour is most vivid from late May to early July, driven by snowmelt raising the water's mineral-colloid concentration. A late-July visit still sees a real blue, just not the most saturated version you'll find on Instagram from three weeks earlier.² Go early in the morning regardless — light angle matters more than calendar precision once you're inside the window.

The famous shot is real. Go before 10am — by the time the coach parties from Sapporo arrive, the rows are a photo queue, not a field.

Niseko in summer runs a different, equally honest pitch: temperate, dry, mid-20s°C by day and cooling toward 18°C at night — explicitly marketed as a heat escape from mainland Japan's brutal July, and noticeably cheaper than the ski season everyone already knows it for.³ Bruce Munro's 1.3-kilometre "Mountain Lights" installation runs at Hanazono through 12 October, and the resort hosts the UCI Gran Fondo World Championships this year — reasons to visit that have nothing to do with snow.

GETTING THERE — AN HONEST ROUTING NOTE

Flight time from Singapore to New Chitose Airport (CTS), Sapporo's gateway, runs roughly ten hours. The honesty flag: SIA's own Singapore-Sapporo service is filed as a genuinely seasonal route this cycle, running late November through February for the ski season — it does not operate in July. A summer visitor's realistic options are Scoot, ANA or JAL, likely via a connection; verify the specific routing and carrier at booking rather than assuming a direct flight exists year-round.⁴

NEW ROOMS, IF YOU'RE BOOKING AHEAD

The hotel pipeline is thickening on both the summer and winter sides of the calendar. Hyatt Centric Sapporo opened in June after a construction-defect delay of more than two years — 216 rooms, including nine suites, right in the practical hub this piece recommends as a base. Aman Niseko, the brand's fourth Japan property and its first full wellness-focused resort, is slated to open sometime this year with 30 standalone mountain-view suite pavilions — an exact date hadn't firmed up as this issue went to press. And Hotel101-Niseko, a 482-room property a two-minute shuttle from the Hirafu lifts, is on track for a December opening timed squarely to the 2026/27 ski season — a genuinely useful data point for anyone already planning the winter trip this summer visit is only a preview of.⁵

~10 hrs Singapore → New Chitose
10–25 Jul lavender's peak window
No SIA direct in July — check Scoot/ANA/JAL
Dec 2026 Hotel101-Niseko opens

Put the three timing facts on this page side by side and a single piece of planning advice falls out: lavender wants you here in the next fortnight, Niseko's new hotel supply wants you here in December, and the Blue Pond actually wanted you here back in June. No single visit optimises for all three — which is exactly why the honest advice, overleaf, is to pick a lane rather than force one trip to be everything Hokkaido offers across a full calendar year.

SOURCES 1. Farm Tomita official; Kyuhoshi (2026). 2. Japan Uncharted; LIVE JAPAN (2026). 3. Elite Havens; Setsu Niseko (2026). 4. Mainly Miles (12 Dec 2025); Trip.com routing data (2026). 5. HotelBank; Aman official; GlobeNewswire (2026). Fares/dates verified where possible; forum sentiment flagged as such.

WHERE TO BASE — AND WHY NOT ALL THREE AT ONCE

Hokkaido is a genuinely large prefecture, and the honest planning call is to pick two of three threads rather than force all of them into one trip. **Sapporo** is the practical hub — best transit, closest to CTS, a strong base for Otaru and Asahiyama day trips. **Furano/Biei** puts you in the lavender fields but with weaker restaurant density and a longer transfer in. **Niseko** is the reader's Whistler parallel, but it's a 2.5–3 hour transfer from CTS in the opposite direction from Furano — a separate multi-day leg, not a day trip. A rotating Sapporo base with a lavender day trip, plus a separate 2–3 night Niseko add-on, is the more realistic shape for a family than trying to loop all three regions in one week.

THE EXPERIENCES, AND THE FOOD

Beyond the lavender fields themselves: **Asahiyama Zoo**, Japan's northernmost, is famous for "behavioural exhibits" — a penguin overhead tunnel, polar bears diving past the viewing glass — and is a genuine hit with an eleven-year-old. **Otaru**, forty minutes from Sapporo by train, offers a stroller-friendly canal walk, glass-blowing demonstrations and music-box shops. Food-wise, Hokkaido's identity rests on cold-water seafood (crab and uni bowls at Hakodate's Morning Market), Sapporo-style miso ramen, and dairy — the island produces roughly half of Japan's milk, and the butter and ice cream show it.¹

WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY

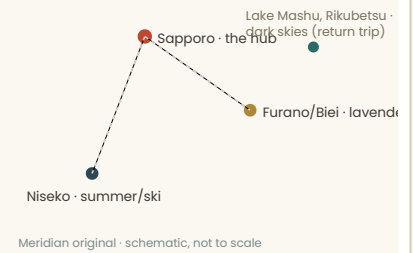
Book the bus before you book the flight. Furano's official summer tour buses run one departure a day per route, and once that day's bus is full, there is no add-on — a genuinely useful, slightly alarming planning fact for a family that shows up without pre-booking.

The famous farms get dusty. TripAdvisor's long-running Hokkaido threads steer visitors to mid-July for peak colour, but warn Farm Tomita specifically gets crowded and dusty — wear flat shoes, and consider a rental car to reach the smaller, less-photographed farms nearby, which regulars describe as "quite charming and less crowded."

The Blue Pond, honestly. Guides quietly concede the colour is most electric in the weeks before this issue's window — a late-July visitor sees something real, just not the most saturated version circulating online.

— **TripAdvisor Hokkaido Forum, "Lavender Trip" & "Furano/Biei Flowers" threads (2026)**

HOKKAIDO · PICK TWO OF THREE



A single week rarely covers all three regions well — the honest itinerary picks two.

20–26°C

HOKKAIDO SUMMER DAYTIME TEMPS —
GENUINELY COOLER THAN MAINLAND
JAPAN

THE HONEST VERDICT

Go now for lavender, or hold out for the ski season — Niseko's winter numbers (15m average annual snowfall) are the real Whistler comparison.

Eastern Hokkaido's dark skies (Lake Mashu, Rikubetsu) are a genuine astro thread, but winter offers better clear-sky odds than a humid July — plant it as a future trip rather than bolting it onto this one.

Rent a car if Furano/Biei is on the itinerary — rural bus schedules are thin and the smaller farms are worth reaching.

MONEY, HONESTLY

Hokkaido typically runs pricier than Kansai or Kyushu — longer domestic transfers, a shorter high season, premium seafood on every menu. The soft yen (¥161–162, p15) cushions that gap meaningfully versus a year or two ago, but it doesn't erase it; budget Hokkaido as the more expensive half of a Japan trip, not the bargain leg.

The astro thread deserves one honest closing note. Lake Mashu's Kamuy Terrace observatory and Rikubetsu's Ginga no Mori Observatory — one of Japan's largest public telescopes — are both genuinely serious dark-sky destinations, officially recognised rather than just marketed as such. But eastern Hokkaido's summer skies carry more cloud and humidity risk than its famously clear winter nights, so treat a July visit as a scouting trip for a future stargazing return rather than the main event. The lavender fields and the dark skies both reward the same discipline: know which season you're actually visiting for, and don't ask one trip to be everything.

SOURCES 1. Feastography; Kyuhoshi (2026). TripAdvisor Hokkaido Forum (2026); Furano Tourism Association; Visit Hokkaido (Lake Mashu, Rikubetsu). Forum sentiment summarised in Meridian's words and flagged as chatter.

THE DIARY · SINGAPORE

The Dated Agenda

A quieter fortnight for the calendar than most, and that's rather the point of a weekend book — the Stadium's return (p5) and a run of small, unreviewed openings (below) are worth more of a family's actual attention than a headline concert would be. Read this page as a genuine "what to do the next two Saturdays" list rather than a scan-and-forget events wire.

SINGAPORE

JUL–AUG 2026

11 JUL **NE1 — NDP Rehearsal Show ★**
NATIONAL STADIUM · FIREWORKS ~7.30PM · FREE · FIRST TIME BACK IN A DECADE

18-25 JUL **NE2 & NE3 rehearsal shows**
SAME FIREWORKS SLOT REPEATS, + 1 AUG

NOW ON **LEGO Botanicals @ Jewel**
THROUGH 26 JUL · ~800,000 BRICKS · NO BOARDING PASS NEEDED

09 AUG **National Day Parade 2026 ★**
NATIONAL STADIUM · BALLOT · FAMILY

PLANNING NOTES

NE1's return to the Stadium after ten years at the Padang is the actual news this week — arrive by 6.30pm for a decent fireworks view from the surrounding park, no ticket required. Digital-hygiene note from p5: watch for job-offer scams asking for Singpass access before the school holidays bring more young people online.

— [NDP.gov.sg](https://ndp.gov.sg); [MissLobang \(Jul\)](#)

THE TABLE

SG'S NEWEST TABLES

This month's openings skew small and unfussy — a \$2.50 pastry, a \$16 pasta bowl, a scone counter and a bread shop nobody's reviewed yet. No queues, no waitlists, just four doors that opened in the last month.

NEW **FreakyNoods**
CHINATOWN · JAPANESE-INSPIRED PASTA FR \$15.90 · TOO NEW TO CALL

21 JUN **Madeleine's Original Egg Tarts**
APERIA MALL · MACAU CHA CHAAN TENG REVIVAL · EARLY REVIEWS WARM

NOW OPEN **Cafe ON:DO**
ALEXANDRA CENTRAL · KOREAN BAKES · VIRAL BUTTER TTEOK \$2.50

NEW **Yunma Bakehouse**
PURVIS ST · JAPANESE-INSPIRED SOURDOUGH · TOO NEW TO CALL

THE BUZZ / THE VERDICT

Madeleine's is the real story: a Tanjong Katong original that closed two years ago when its landlord sold the building, now revived by the founders' own trained successors at Aperia. Early reviews call the egg tart "crispy, flaky," with some hot dishes still finding their feet — a nostalgia return worth the visit, not yet a full verdict.

Cafe ON:DO quietly avoids the over-styled "photo corner" Korean-café cliché — reviewers like it precisely for being a compact, honest bake counter rather than a set.

— [Eatbook](#); [DanielFoodDiary](#); [Time Out SG \(Jun–Jul\)](#)

TOO NEW TO CALL

NOSTALGIA RETURN

SUB-\$20

The Table's honesty rule cuts both ways this issue: three of four picks above are genuinely too fresh to have earned a verdict, and we're saying so rather than manufacturing a review. Madeleine's is the exception precisely because it has history behind it — a real prior run, a real closure, real customers who remember the original. That's a different, older kind of anticipation than a debut restaurant's, and it's worth naming as its own category: the comeback, not the launch.

SOURCES [NDP.gov.sg](https://ndp.gov.sg); [MissLobang \(Jul 2026\)](#). The Table: [Eatbook](#), [DanielFoodDiary](#), [Time Out SG](#), [Must Share News](#), [Great New Places \(Jun–Jul\)](#). Buzz summarised in our words; "too new to call" flagged honestly.

THE DIARY · JAPAN & THE REGION

Lantern Season

JAPAN

THE FESTIVAL SEASON

- 13-16
JUL

Mitama Festival, Yasukuni Shrine ★
TOKYO · 30,000+ PAPER LANTERNS · NEW TO THE DIARY THIS ISSUE
- 17-24
JUL

Gion Matsuri, Kyoto ★
YAMABOKO FLOAT PROCESSIONS · YOIYAMA STANDS, BOOK AHEAD
- 25
JUL

Sumida River Fireworks, Tokyo ★
~20,000 FIREWORKS · ~1M PEOPLE · ARRIVE VERY EARLY
- 29-01
JUL-AUG

Tsukiji Hongwanji Bon Dance
TOKYO · NIGHTLY BON ODORI, 7-9PM
- ON

Hiroshi Sugimoto exhibition
NATIONAL MUSEUM OF MODERN ART, TOKYO · A PHOTOGRAPHY PILGRIMAGE
- JUL

Grand Sumo, Nagoya (Basho)
THE JULY TOURNAMENT

FOR THE CAMERA BAG

Hiroshi Sugimoto, National Museum of Modern Art, Tokyo — a genuine pilgrimage for this reader's photography interest, running now. **Ron Mueck**, hyperreal figurative sculpture, Mori Art Museum — a strong "worth the trip" pairing on the same visit.

THE WIDER REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

- 15-22
AUG

Hamilton Island Race Week
WHITSUNDAYS, AUSTRALIA · MAJOR YACHTING FESTIVAL
- 30
AUG

Sydney Marathon ★
WORLD MARATHON MAJORS · HARBOUR BRIDGE TO OPERA HOUSE
- 13-16
AUG

Obon, nationwide (Japan)
TRANSPORT SURGES NATIONWIDE — PLAN AROUND IT, NOT THROUGH IT

PLANNING NOTES

Book the seats early. Gion's Yoiyama paid viewing stands typically sell out one to two months ahead.

Sydney Marathon's Major status is recent enough that entry demand is climbing fast — a genuine ★ pick for a "big trip" year, not a routine local race anymore.

Mind the heat. Japanese summer festivals routinely run past 35°C — the same logic that makes Hokkaido's cooler air (p21) worth the extra flight time.

— **japan-guide; Tokyo Weekender; Savvy Tokyo (2026)**

HAND-OFF FROM THE TRAVEL DESK

The Travel Desk set the destination and the landscape; the Diary carries the dates. Hokkaido's lavender window closes in about a fortnight — if it's on the shortlist, this is the moment to book, not browse.

1-2 mo

HOW FAR AHEAD PAID FESTIVAL STANDS TYPICALLY SELL

ON THE FURTHER HORIZON

The AFC Women's Asian Cup 2026 runs across the region this autumn, with matches expected in Japan, Korea, China and the Philippines — dates were still firming up at press time, worth a placeholder in the calendar rather than a booking yet.

Notice the shape of this fortnight's agenda: a cluster of Japan's biggest summer festivals lands in the same ten days as Hokkaido's lavender peak (p21) — which means a reader chasing both needs to choose a lane, Honshu's matsuri season or Hokkaido's cooler fields, rather than a single trip that tries to do both justice.

SOURCES Tokyo Weekender; Savvy Tokyo; japan-guide.com event calendar (Jul 2026); The New Daily (Hamilton Island). Dates follow published committee schedules; verify current-year details before booking.

THE LONG READ · AN ESSAY

I Refute It Thus

A shark that no one had ever seen alive was alive the whole time. A market's belief in a chip shortage became the chip shortage's price. This week's book is full of things that are real whether or not anyone is looking — and a few that are only real because someone said so. Telling the two apart turns out to be the actual job.

In 1710, the Irish bishop George Berkeley published *A Treatise Concerning the Principles of Human Knowledge*, arguing a claim that still sounds like a party trick more than a philosophy: *esse est percipi* — to be is to be perceived. A table exists, on Berkeley's account, not as some brute lump of matter sitting there regardless, but as a bundle of qualities perceived by a mind — colour, hardness, shape — with no "matter" left over once you subtract the perceiving. It is a strange, oddly airtight argument, and for half a century nobody managed to refute it properly.¹

Then, in 1763, the essayist and lexicographer Samuel Johnson tried. Walking with his biographer James Boswell after a discussion of Berkeley's ingenious sophistry, Johnson — by Boswell's account, published in his *Life of Johnson* in 1791 — strode up to a large stone and kicked it with such force that he rebounded off it, declaring: "I refute it thus."² It is a famous non-argument. Kicking a stone doesn't touch Berkeley's actual claim, which was never that stones don't hurt your foot, only that "hurting your foot" is itself a perception, not proof of some perception-independent stone-in-itself. Johnson's stone is bad philosophy and a great instinct: some things, it insists, are just *there*, indifferent to whether a mind has gotten around to noticing them.

Johnson's stone is bad philosophy and a great instinct: some things are just there, whether or not anyone has noticed yet.

This week's book is unusually full of Johnson's stones. On page 16, a shark family a hundred and twenty-five

million years old — old enough to have watched the actual continents rearrange themselves — was finally filmed alive, seven hundred metres deeper than anyone had ever recorded it. Every previous account of *Mitsukurina owstoni* came from a body, dead on a hook or a trawl deck; the animal itself had simply been swimming down there the entire time, entirely unbothered by seven hundred years of ichthyology not getting around to it. On page 21, Furano's lavender fields are hitting their single most vivid ten days of the year at this exact moment, whether or not a single reader of this magazine boards a flight to see them. The bloom doesn't care. It's a stone, and Johnson would have kicked it approvingly.

The same is true, in a harder register, of a bone. This issue's Fitness desk (p18) reports a small Canadian trial in which women randomised to a waitlist — no intervention, just the ordinary passage of nine months — lost lean mass, leg power and lumbar-spine bone density, entirely without anyone doing anything to them. That loss didn't wait to be measured, or perceived, or worried about. It simply happened, the way a stone simply sits there, and the trial's real finding is less "lifting helps" than "decline is not a neutral default that requires an active cause — it is the cause, running quietly in the background whether or not a scan has caught up to it yet."

Johnson never actually met Berkeley in this exchange — the bishop had been dead eleven years by 1763 — which is itself a small, fitting irony. The kicked stone wasn't a rebuttal delivered to its target. It was a demonstration performed for an audience of one biographer, who happened to write it down well enough that it outlived every formal essay written against Berkeley's idealism in the century that followed. Sometimes the enduring argument isn't the correct one. It's the one somebody happened to record.

SOURCES 1. George Berkeley, *A Treatise Concerning the Principles of Human Knowledge* (1710). 2. James Boswell, *Life of Samuel Johnson* (1791), entry for 6 Aug 1763.

But not everything in the book is a stone, and the interesting cases are the ones where Berkeley, not Johnson, turns out to be right — where the perceiving really is doing the work. The clearest example sits inside John Maynard Keynes's *General Theory of Employment, Interest and Money* (1936), in a passage about a newspaper contest popular in his day: readers picked the six prettiest faces from a hundred photographs, and the prize went not to whoever picked the faces *they* found prettiest, but to whoever's picks matched the average preference of all entrants. The rational strategy, Keynes noted, isn't to judge beauty. It's to guess what everyone else will guess everyone else will guess is beautiful — perception of perception, several layers deep, with no stone at the bottom of it.¹

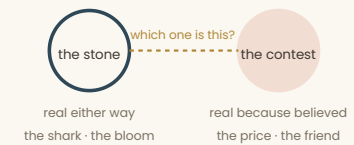
SK hynix's Nasdaq debut this week (p7) is a small, clean beauty contest, resolved in real time. The \$26.5 billion raise wasn't priced against some Johnson-style fact about the intrinsic worth of a memory-chip maker sitting there independent of anyone's opinion. It was priced against a collective bet that *enough other people* would keep believing the memory supercycle has years left to run — and on Friday, when the stock closed up 13%, belief and price simply became the same number. That isn't naivety. In a Keynesian market, correctly reading the room is the correct analysis, in a way that would baffle Dr. Johnson and would have made perfect sense to Bishop Berkeley.

SK hynix's price wasn't measuring some fact about the company sitting there independent of opinion. It was measuring whether enough people believed the same story — and this week, belief and price simply became the same number.

The friendship study on page 17 turns out to be the same shape at human scale, and it's the most quietly radical finding in this whole issue. Nearly 1,500 people, tested properly, showed that a friendship's satisfaction isn't predicted by how *actually* alike two people are — the Johnson-style, stone-kickable fact of matching personality traits. It's predicted by how favourably each person *perceives* the other. The perceiving isn't a proxy for some underlying compatibility fact you could measure with a better instrument. In this domain, the perceiving is the compatibility. Berkeley, a few hundred years early, might simply have called that finding obvious.

Even Hokkaido's tour buses (p22), oddly enough, sit closer to Keynes than to Johnson. A field of lavender is a stone; a fully booked bus is a contest — its "fullness" is nothing more than enough other travellers deciding, independently, to book the same departure. The forums' advice to "book the bus before you book the flight" is, without either party noticing, a beauty-contest strategy: guess what enough other people will guess, and act before they do.

TWO KINDS OF REAL



Meridian original
the question worth asking each time

Not every claim in the news is the same kind of claim.

THE THREADS

The goblin shark (p16) — a stone, unwatched for 125M years.

Hokkaido's lavender (p21) — a stone, blooming on its own schedule.

SK hynix (p7) — a contest, resolved by belief becoming price.

The friendship study (p17) — a contest, at human scale.

STOP-EM's control group (p18) — a stone: bone loss that didn't wait for anyone's attention.

SOURCES 1. J.M. Keynes, *The General Theory of Employment, Interest and Money* (1936), Ch. 12. Cross-references verified against this issue's own reporting, p7, p16, p17, p18, p21.

Which brings us to the hardest case in the book, and the one this issue had to correct itself on: the Hormuz ceasefire. On Friday, Washington declared it "over" — a statement delivered with the flat, stone-kicking confidence of a fact being reported. But the negotiators were back in the same Doha rooms within the day, the same channel that had never actually closed (p3). Was "over" a Johnson-style claim about a fact in the world? Evidently not, since the fact it purported to describe kept right on not matching it. Was it a Keynes-style beauty contest, where saying "over" loudly enough might have made it so — the diplomatic equivalent of a price target announced with enough conviction to become self-fulfilling? Also, evidently, not: the talks resumed regardless of who said what.

The honest answer is that a ceasefire's status is neither kind of claim cleanly — it's a moving negotiation being narrated in real time by parties with every incentive to narrate it advantageously, and the only responsible move is to notice that the label and the substance have come apart, and say so, rather than pick whichever version flatters the story you'd already decided to write. That is, not coincidentally, exactly what this issue's Macro Desk had to do with Japan's ten-year bond (p15): last issue reported a Friday-morning relief rally to 2.77%; this issue found credible reporting putting the same yield near a fresh three-decade high. Rather than silently picking the more comfortable number, we printed the conflict. That correction is a small, unglamorous example of the entire argument of this essay, performed rather than merely described.

The honest move, when a label and the substance underneath it have come apart, is to say so — not to quietly pick whichever version flatters the story you'd already decided to write.

There's a reason this matters beyond a magazine's footnotes. A reader managing a portfolio, a

household, and a career is making exactly this judgment call dozens of times a week without naming it: is this news item a stone (verify it, and act on the verified fact) or a contest (recognise that enough people believing it will make it true, and position for the belief, not the fact)? Get the category wrong in either direction and you either waste effort re-verifying something that was never in question, or you argue with a stone that was never listening. Gold's price (p15), read correctly, is mostly a contest about real yields and fear; a chair-stand test's result (p18) is a stone about your own muscle, full stop, indifferent to how you feel about it that morning.

Berkeley never really lost the argument to a kicked stone — Johnson's foot proved nothing except that feet hurt, which nobody was disputing. But Johnson wasn't entirely wrong either, just wrong about the target. Some things in this week's news are stones: they will be exactly as true in a month whether this magazine writes about them or not, and the discipline is simply going and looking — at a shark, a bond yield, a bathroom scale. Other things are contests, all the way down, and the discipline there is different: understanding that enough people agreeing is not a bug in the system but the entire mechanism, and reading the room honestly instead of pretending you're reading a fact.

The reader who's followed this magazine's callbacks will recognise the family resemblance: the map that isn't the territory (No. 09), the said and the done (No. 13), the word that finally arrived (No. 23). This is their cousin, not their repeat — not "does the word match the world," but "which kind of world is this word even trying to match." Kick the stone if it's a stone. If it's a beauty contest, put down your foot, and go read the room instead.

One closing case, small enough to fit in a single sentence: a goblin shark that swam unwitnessed for a hundred and twenty-five million years was, this whole time, exactly as real as it is now that we've finally filmed it. Nothing about the animal changed the week the camera arrived. What changed was only our side of the relationship — which is, itself, the entire and only power that watching ever really has.

THE LAST WORD

Go and Look, or Read the Room

A shark swam unwitnessed for a hundred and twenty-five million years and didn't need us to notice. A chip stock's price became true the moment enough people agreed it was. Somewhere between those two lies most of what you'll read this week — a ceasefire relabelled without changing, a bond yield that depends which desk you ask. The job isn't picking a philosophy and sticking to it. It's asking, case by case: is this a stone, or a contest? Then act accordingly — go and look, or go and read the room.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES — The World: NBC News, CNN, Times of Israel, US News, Al Jazeera, GCC statement, Yahoo Sports. Singapore: NDP.gov.sg, MissLobang, Singapore Police Force, Mothership. Property: URA, CBRE, ERA, EdgeProp, Stacked Homes. Technology: CNBC, Al Jazeera, Forbes, ComfyUI GitHub. The Kit: Gizmodo, The Gadgeteer, Engadget. Connected Home: Hueblog, Matter Alpha. The Good Life: Robb Report, WatchPro, The Art Newspaper. Screen & Sound: Variety, Deadline, Boxoffice Pro, Metacritic, Paste. The Family Desk: Rep. Foushee press release, RAND/JAMA Pediatrics, STAT News. The Macro Desk: Trading Economics, CNBC, Yahoo Finance. Curiosities: Journal of Fish Biology, UWA, ScienceDaily, Space.com. Love & Life: Social Psychological and Personality Science, PsyPost, British Journal of Health Psychology. Fitness: Bone Reports, JAMA Network Open, Forbes. The Travel Desk: Mainly Miles, Farm Tomita, Japan Uncharted, TripAdvisor Hokkaido Forum, LTA. The Diary: japan-guide, Tokyo Weekender, Savvy Tokyo, Eatbook, DanielFoodDiary. The Long Read: Berkeley (1710), Boswell (1791), Keynes (1936).

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.